

CORENTIN CHARLES / FRENCH NAVY

26
RAFALE-Ms TO BE ACQUIRED BY THE INDIAN NAVY

₹63,000 CRORE
TOTAL COST, INCLUDING WEAPONS, SIMULATORS, CREW TRAINING, ETC.

IR POWER

BLUNT THE THREAT FROM ADVERSARIES IN THE INDO-PACIFIC

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

PACKING A PUNCH

- A carrier-based, multirole fighter jet, the Rafale-M will equip the Indian Navy with advanced strike, air defence and reconnaissance capabilities
- Its need was felt especially due to multiple issues with the existing MiG 29K fleet and delays in developing indigenous fighter jets for the navy
- With its ability to operate from IAF bases along India's northern borders, it will also bolster the air force's existing fleet of 36 Rafales, helping India project power across multiple fronts

is seen as an emergency measure, as the navy does not have enough jets for its aircraft carriers. It has been using the MiG-29K after the British-made Sea Harriers were phased out in 2016.

Armed with advanced weaponry like the SCALP 560-km-range cruise missile, AM39 Exocet anti-ship missile and Meteor air-to-air missile, the Rafale-M is a multirole jet capable of long-range precision strikes against ships, air targets and land-based threats. The French navy has been operating it since 2004 and has a fleet of around 48 aircraft. Operating from the carrier *Charles de Gaulle*, Rafale-Ms were actively involved in Operation Chammal (2014-2022) in Iraq and Syria as part of the US-led coalition against the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria (ISIS).

"Its versatility extends beyond the seas, with the ability to operate from IAF bases along India's northern borders, bolstering the IAF's Rafale fleet. This dual-role capability ensures India can project power across multiple fronts, from maritime chokepoints like the Malacca Strait to contested Himalayan borders, countering China's carrier-driven power projection and Pakistan's asymmetric naval threats," explains a senior defence official.

Admiral Arun Prakash, former navy chief, who was also a naval aviator, tells INDIA TODAY that the Rafale-M, with its advanced multirole capabilities, positions India to effectively counter challenges from adversaries, especially China's expanding naval presence in the Indo-Pacific. Naval experts claim that the Rafale-M can also deploy India's air-delivered nuclear bombs, bolstering the survivability and credibility of its second-strike capability from sea.